

Radiotherapy and pregnancy

Radiotherapy uses high-energy rays to destroy cancer cells. It is not usually given during pregnancy as it may harm the developing baby.

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About pregnancy and radiotherapy

[Radiotherapy](#) uses high-energy rays to destroy cancer cells. It is not usually given during pregnancy, as even a low dose may harm the developing baby.

If radiotherapy is urgent, it may be given to a part of the body that is not close to the womb. For example, if a [tumour in the brain](#) is causing increased pressure. Usually, radiotherapy happens after the birth.

Breast cancer radiotherapy and pregnancy

Radiotherapy is usually recommended after an operation to remove only the area of the breast affected by the cancer. This is called [breast-conserving surgery](#). Radiotherapy may also be given to the lymph nodes near the breast area.

You usually have [radiotherapy](#) 6 to 8 weeks after surgery. If your diagnosis happens later in your pregnancy, you may be able to delay radiotherapy until after the baby is born.

If you have [breast cancer](#), you may also need [chemotherapy](#). You may have chemotherapy before or after surgery. But it can take several months to finish the cycles of chemotherapy you need. This usually means that if you have chemotherapy before radiotherapy, you will have had your baby before it is time to start radiotherapy.

You may be diagnosed early in your pregnancy and not need chemotherapy. This may mean you have to wait more than 6 months after surgery before you have radiotherapy. This delay could increase the risk of the cancer coming back in the breast. In this situation, your surgeon may advise you to have the whole of the breast removed. This is called a [mastectomy](#).

After a mastectomy, you may need radiotherapy to the chest.

Cervical cancer radiotherapy and pregnancy

Radiotherapy is never given to the pelvic area during pregnancy.

If you are not pregnant, the main treatment is radiotherapy with chemotherapy. This is called [chemoradiation](#). It is given when:

- [cervical cancer](#) is larger
- it has spread into surrounding tissue.

Your doctors may advise that chemoradiation is the best treatment. If you are in early pregnancy, they may recommend that you think about [ending the pregnancy](#).

If you decide to continue with the pregnancy, you must wait until you are 14 weeks pregnant to have [chemotherapy](#). You must wait until after the birth for [radiotherapy](#). This may be a serious risk to your health. Your doctors and nurses will give you a lot of support to help you to cope.

If you are later in your pregnancy, you will start chemotherapy straight away. You then have radiotherapy after the baby is born.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Below is a sample of the sources used in our pregnancy and cancer information. If you would like more information about the sources we use, please contact us at informationproductionteam@macmillan.org.uk

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

How we can help

Macmillan Support Line

The Macmillan Support Line is a free and confidential service for people living with and affected by cancer. If you need to talk, we'll listen.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help